FRENCH REVOLUTIONARY WARS

REVOLUTION IN 1789 PLUNGED France into a political crisis that led to the abolition of the French monarchy and war with most of Europe. The French navy suffered grievously in this upheaval, with most of its officers either resigning or dismissed and indiscipline rampant. At war with France from 1793, the British at first comfortably had the upper hand at sea. When the Spanish and Dutch became France's allies, however, British complacency was shattered. The threat of a French invasion of England was averted in 1797 by the defeat of the Spanish at Cape St. Vincent, followed by the crushing of the Dutch at Camperdown. But in the same year as these triumphs, mutinies at Spithead and the Nore temporarily paralyzed the Royal Navy, exposing the strain on morale in a long drawn out conflict. Evading a slack British blockade, the French were able to make landings in Ireland and Wales. Britain found its savior in Admiral Horatio Nelson, whose stunning victory over a French fleet at the Nile in 1798 ruined General Napoleon Bonaparte's military expedition to Egypt and heralded a new era of British naval supremacy.

FRENCH REVOLUTIONARY WARS



THE FIRST OF JUNE

Date	June 1, 1794
Location	Atlantic Ocean, west of Ushant
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	FRANCE

COMMANDERS

Richard Howe	Louis Thomas Villaret de Joyeuse

FORCES

Ships: 25	**Ships:** 26

LOSSES

Men: 1,200 casualties **Ships:** none	**Men:** 4,000 casualties, 3,000 captured **Ships:** 7

THE FIRST OF JUNE

On May 17, 1794, the French Atlantic Fleet commanded by Louis Thomas Villaret de Joyeuse sailed from Brest. Its mission was to ensure the safe arrival in France of a food convoy from the United States, desperately awaited by a hungry people. The Royal Navy's Channel Fleet under Lord Howe had been sent to intercept the food convoy, but Howe was more concerned with seizing an opportunity to engage the French navy. He sighted Villaret's ships on May 25 and gave chase.

On May 28, Howe caught up with the French rear, which was defended by the 110-gun *Révolutionnaire*. The next day a more substantial skirmish ended with damage to ships on both sides. Thick fog then interrupted the engagement, but June 1 dawned clear. Villaret could no longer evade battle.

Howe, holding the weather gage, adopted a bold and unconventional plan that envisaged the annihilation of the enemy fleet. Each of his ships was to pass individually through the French line and come up in the lee of an opponent. The French ships would be raked as their line was crossed, and then blocked from escape to leeward. Superior British gunnery would do the rest. But Howe's attack did not go to smoothly, for he apparently failed to persuade his captains to follow his plan. Only seven of his ships in fact crossed the French line, some making no attempt to do so. This was sufficient, however, to break up the French formation and ensure a brutal pell-mell battle. Howe's flagship *Queen Charlotte* passed behind Villaret's *Montagne* and simultaneously engaged the French flagship and the 90-gun *Jacobin*. *Brunswick*, captained by John Harvey, collided with *Vengeur du Peuple* and the two ships became entangled, firing broadsides hull-to-hull. Harvey was mortally wounded amid the general



Blunderbuss pistol
With its bell mouth ensuring a wide spread of shot at close range, the blunderbuss pistol was a perfect boarding weapon. This example has a spring-loaded bayonet, operated by the rear trigger.